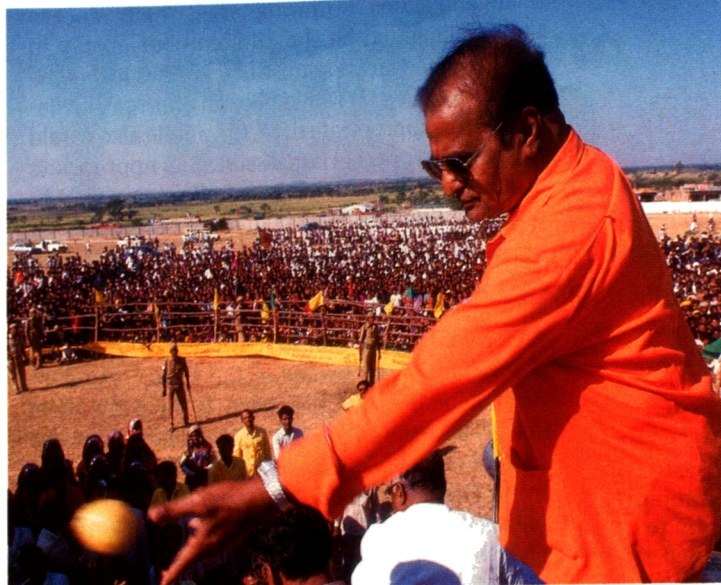
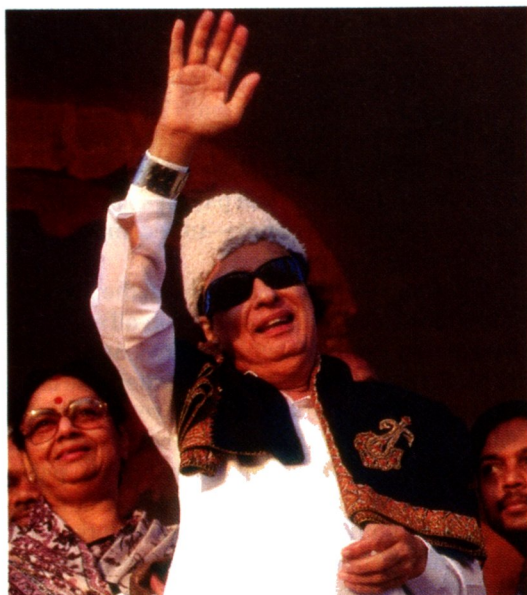




## MGR (LEFT) AND NTR ESTABLISHED A HYSTERICAL CONNECT WITH THEIR BASE.

bastion since Independence. But NTR harped on the self-respect of the Telugu-speaking people after the Indira Gandhi-led Congress at the Centre changed four chief ministers between 1978 and 1982.

The advantage that political parties headed by popular actors enjoy is the presence of adoring fans who swell the venues of the rallies. In turn, actors-turned-politicians with their histrionics and role-playing, establish a hysterical connect with their base. Chiranjeevi may not have it as easy, not just because he is not blessed with the charisma of NTR. Despite an ardent fan-following, Chiranjeevi's task is made difficult by the fact that unlike the servile Congress chief ministers of the 1970s and '80s, the incumbent Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy is known to be a doer. He is about to complete the full five-year term and has rallied the Congress behind him like no chief minister has done in the state since Kasu Brahmananda Reddy in the '70s.

This explains why Chiranjeevi is taking his own time to build the party and stepping up his campaign progressively. He visited Sircilla in Karimnagar district for a first-hand appraisal of the plight of handloom weavers, some of whom, debt-ridden, have committed suicide, and to Polepally in Mahbubnagar district to understand the issues of resettlement of farmers who are being moved out for the creation of a Special Economic Zone. He will then be off for road shows during which he will use a custom-built Eicher Mitsubishi 1095 van as a moving dais. Fitted with a high-end sound system with 10 speakers designed to carry Chiranjeevi's voice across to audiences in a 200-m radius, the vehicle evidently has been inspired by the Chaitanya Ratham that NTR used to travel across Andhra Pradesh to woo supporters.

Flashback to 2003, Rajasekhara Reddy, the then leader of the Opposition went on padayatra and was successful in turning the tables on the TDP rule of Naidu in elections that followed the next year. Now, Naidu has already completed a 117-day-long yatra and will set off on a second round from October 2. It is against this backdrop that Chiranjeevi arrives promising change. Carping critics are dismissive and liken Chiranjeevi's party to that of Tamil actor Vijayakanth who launched the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) in September 2005 with much fanfare in Tamil Nadu. It turned out to be a "one seat wonder" in the last assembly elections. The actor's admirers can only hope that his assault on the established parties will end as it began—with a bang and not a whimper.

**THE FLOP SHOW:**  
Vijayakanth's DMDK ended up being a one-seat wonder in the last assembly elections in Tamil Nadu



H.K. RAJASEKHAR